



GUIDE of the Abbey

HISTORY

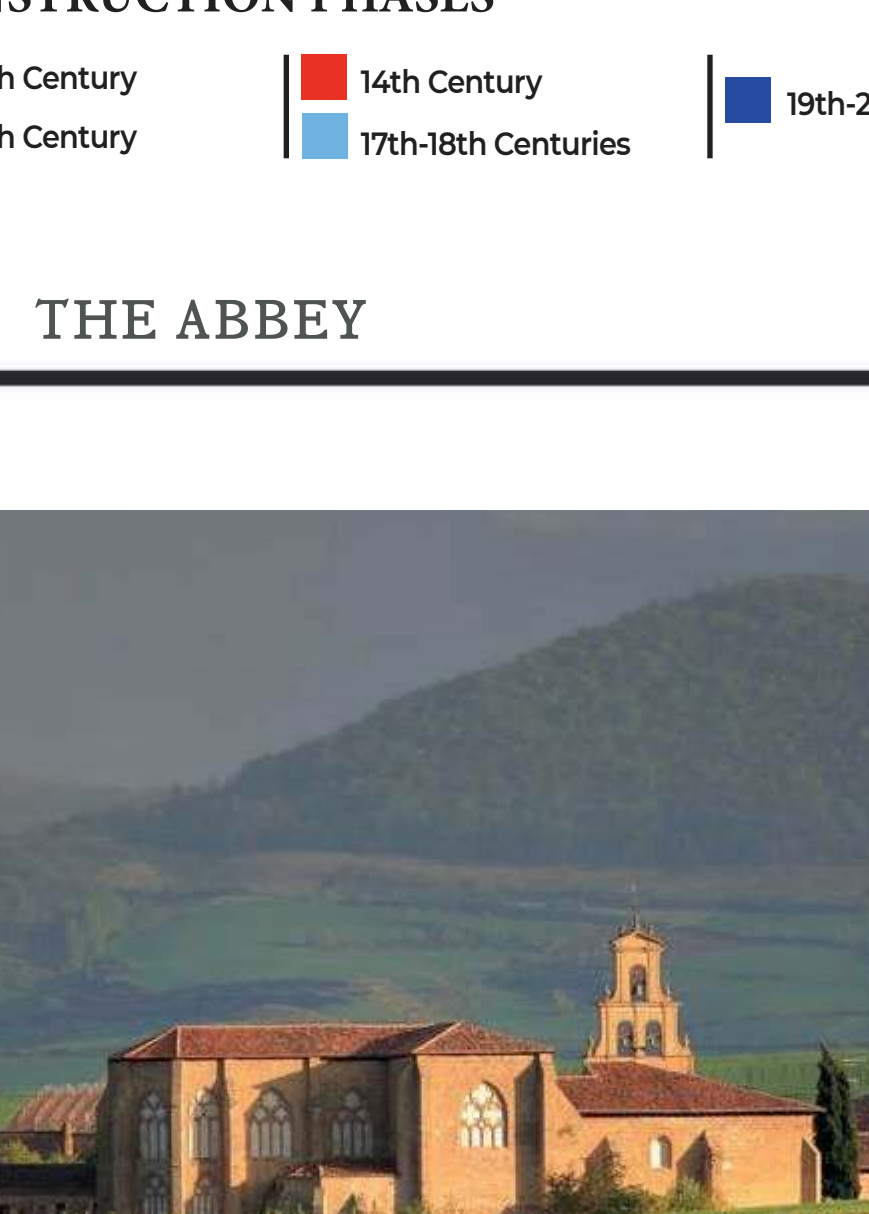
This Abbey has been home to a cloistered community of Cistercian nuns since its foundation in 1170. The Cistercian Order emerged in 1098 as a reform within the Benedictine Order, aiming to return to a stricter observance of the Rule of Saint Benedict of Nursia. This movement was led by Saint Robert, Saint Alberic, and Saint Stephen Harding, the first abbots of Cîteaux.

In 1170, Count Lope Díaz de Haro and his wife, Lady Aldonza Ruiz de Castro, donated the villages of Cañas and Canillas to the community of nuns from the monastery of Hayuela, to found an Abbey under the protection of their county seat, Nájera. Their daughter, Lady Urraca López de Haro y Ruiz de Castro, considered the second founder, oversaw the construction of the 13th-century building while serving as Abbess. She was declared Blessed and is listed in the Cistercian martyrology. Her incorrupt body lies in her tomb in the Chapter House of the Abbey.

The works begun by the López de Haro family were halted at the transept for nearly three centuries, until the abbacy of Leonor de Osorio, who continued the central nave and commissioned the construction of the Main Altarpiece in the 16th century.

During the 17th and 18th centuries, the Cloister was completed, and in the 19th and 20th centuries, various convent buildings were added, shaping the Abbey's current layout.

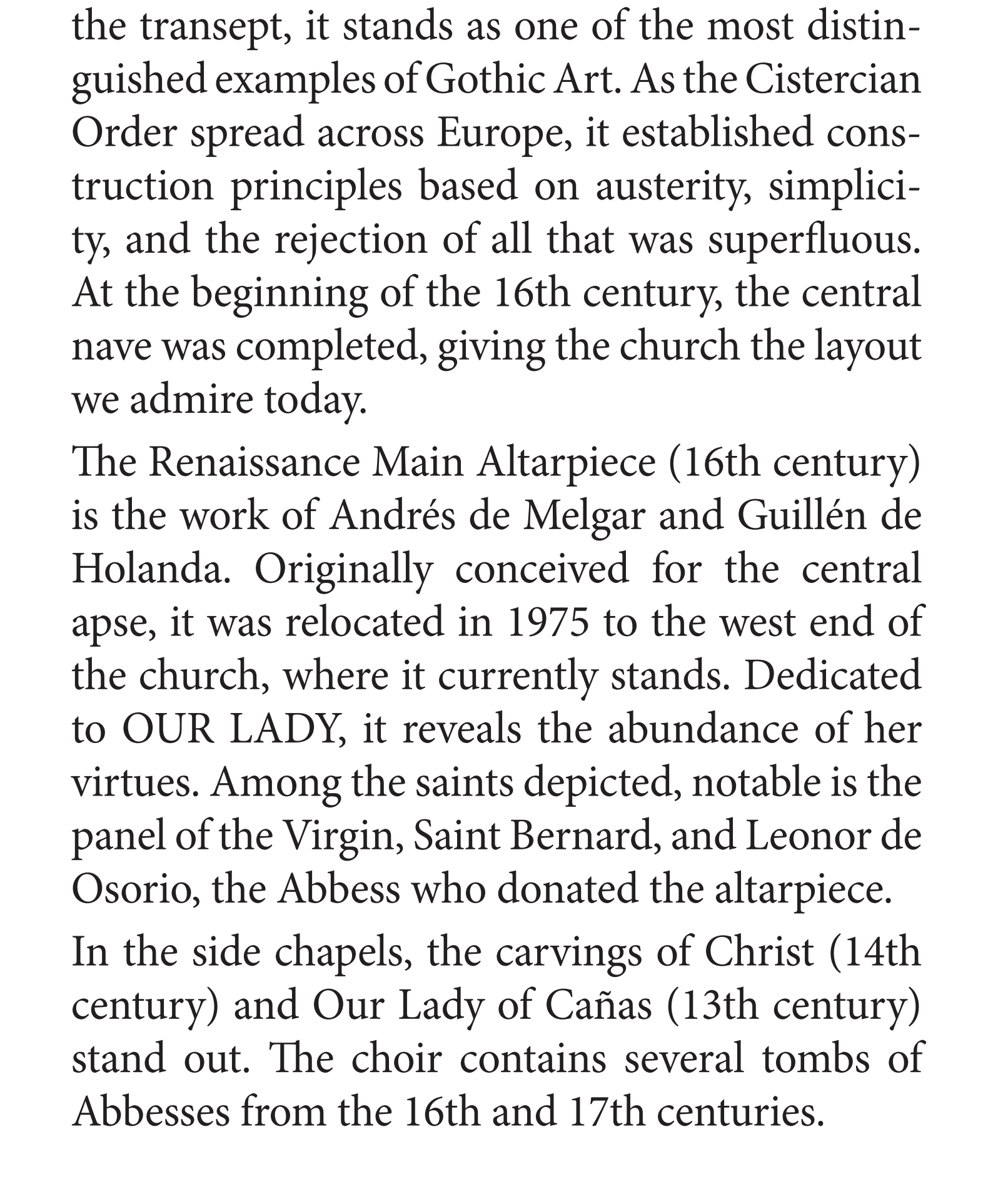
PLAN OF THE CISTERCIAN ABBEY



CONSTRUCTION PHASES



THE ABBEY

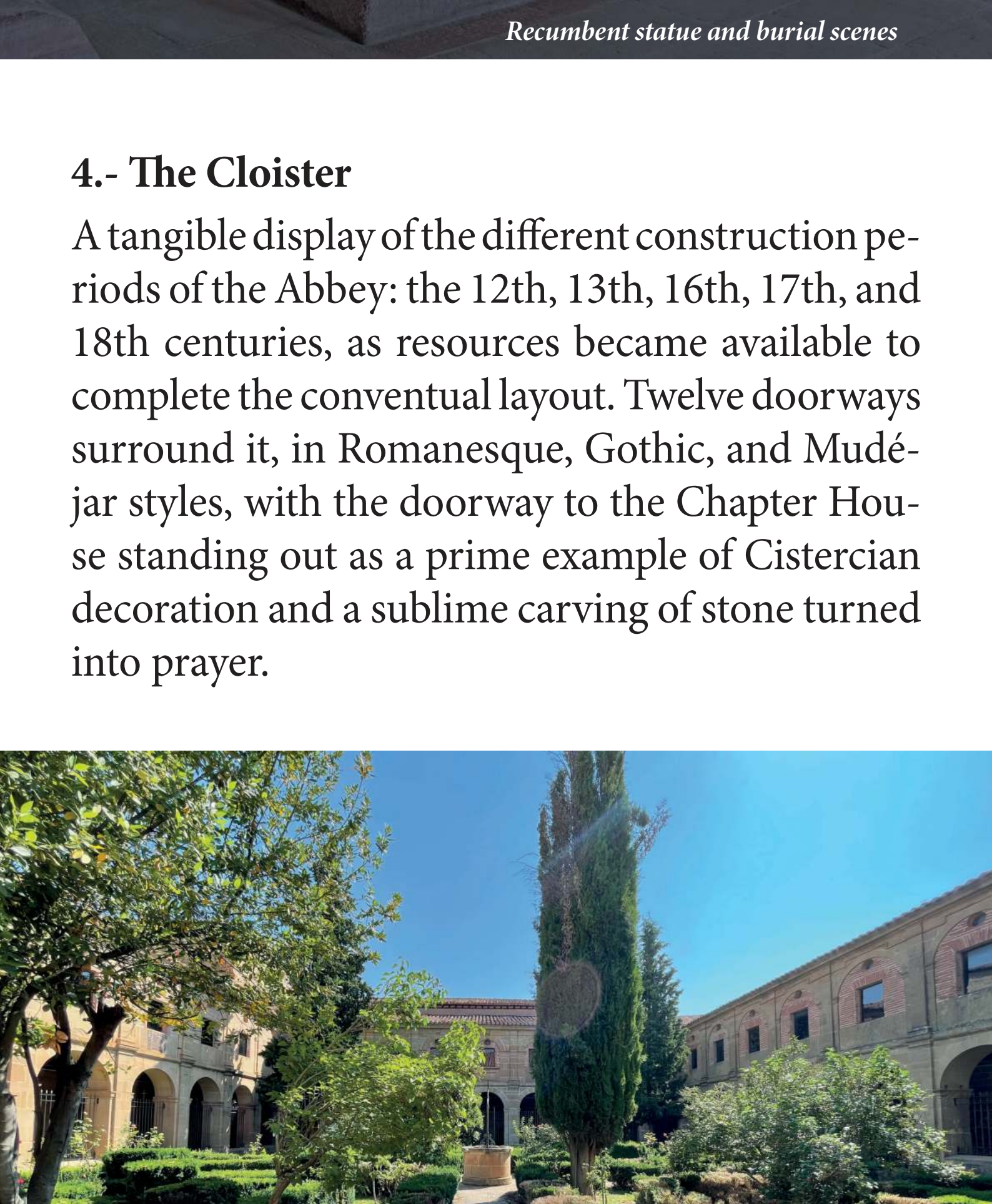


2.- The Church

Of the purest and finest Cistercian-Gothic style, the church possesses an unusual sense of lightness thanks to its luminosity, which, through twenty windows, allows us to partake in the Grace of God—identified by Saint Bernard with White Light. Built during the 13th century, from the apses to the transept, it stands as one of the most distinguished examples of Gothic Art. As the Cistercian Order spread across Europe, it established construction principles based on austerity, simplicity, and the rejection of all that was superfluous. At the beginning of the 16th century, the central nave was completed, giving the church the layout we admire today.

The Renaissance Main Altarpiece (16th century) is the work of Andrés de Melgar and Guillén de Holanda. Originally conceived for the central apse, it was relocated in 1975 to the west end of the church, where it currently stands. Dedicated to OUR LADY, it reveals the abundance of her virtues. Among the saints depicted, notable is the panel of the Virgin, Saint Bernard, and Leonor de Osorio, the Abbess who donated the altarpiece.

In the side chapels, the carvings of Christ (14th century) and Our Lady of Cañas (13th century) stand out. The choir contains several tombs of Abbesses from the 16th and 17th centuries.



Church Apse

3.- Chapter House

One of the most beautiful parts of the Abbey complex, this room dates from the second half of the 13th century. Originally used for the meetings of the Nuns' Chapter, it was later transformed into a burial place. Its magnificent decoration follows the Cistercian directive of using vegetal motifs, as Saint Bernard believed that human imagery could distract monks and nuns from prayer.

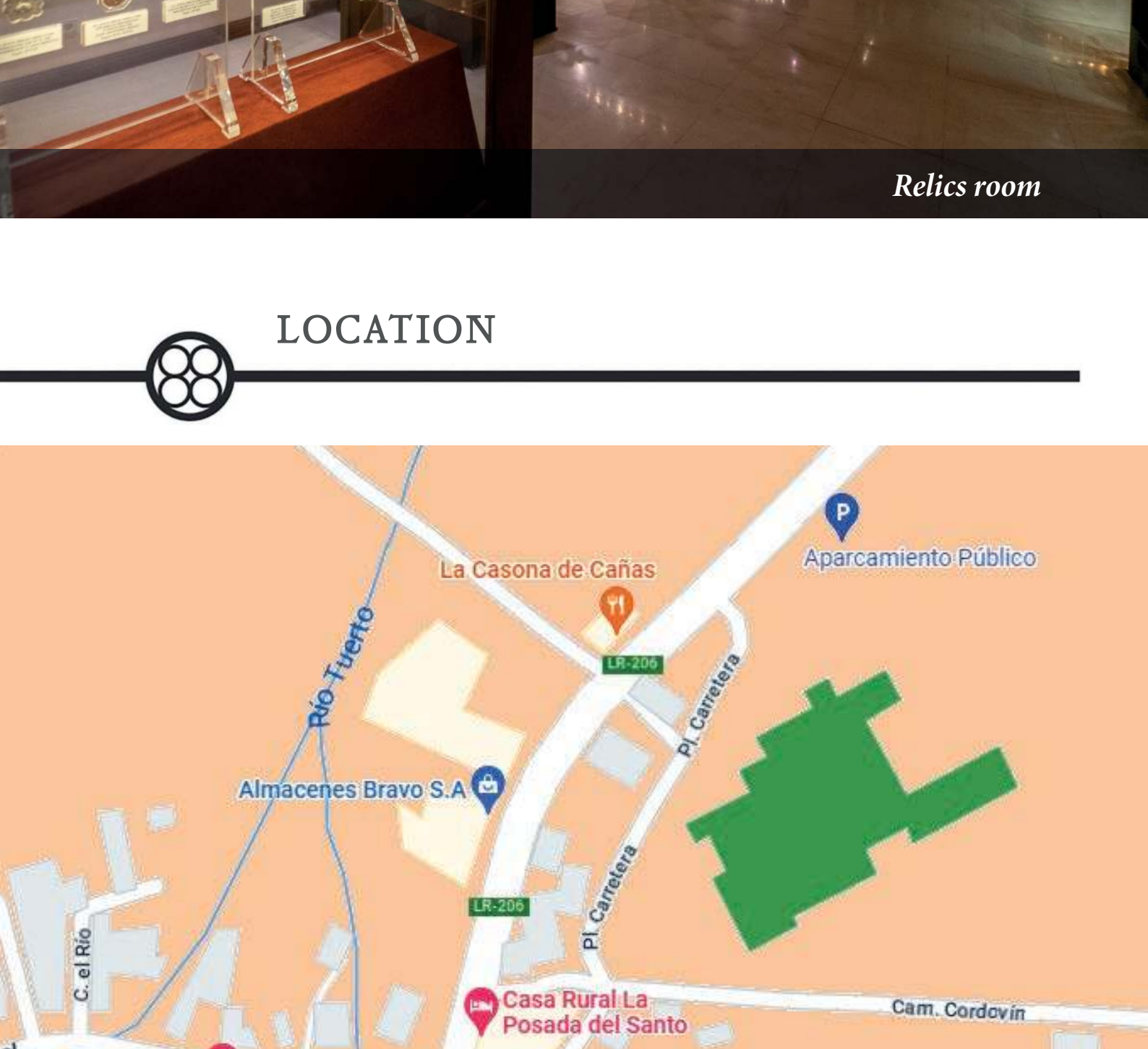
Among the tombs it contains, the most notable is that of Blessed Urraca López de Haro, an outstanding example of 13th-century Spanish funerary art, featuring a recumbent statue and scenes of the burial. Her body remains completely incorrupt within. On either side lie the tombs of four abbesses from the 13th and 14th centuries.



Recumbent statue and burial scenes

4.- The Cloister

A tangible display of the different construction periods of the Abbey: the 12th, 13th, 16th, 17th, and 18th centuries, as resources became available to complete the conventual layout. Twelve doorways surround it, in Romanesque, Gothic, and Mudéjar styles, with the doorway to the Chapter House standing out as a prime example of Cistercian decoration and a sublime carving of stone turned into prayer.



Cloister of the Monastery

5.- Cilla - Museum

Originally a storage and cellar building (13th century), where crops were kept, it now houses a spiritual and artistic harvest, which constitutes almost the entire collection of the Abbey's own holdings. Small altarpieces, reliefs, paintings, and sculptures, which began to expand this collection from the late 16th century onward. Displayed in five main themes: The Saints of the Cistercian Order, The Early Years of Christ's Life, The Passion and Redemption, The Virgin, and The Saints; it provides insight into the mysteries of religion, serving as a clear catechetical element for every visitor.

Mysteries of Religion and Relics of the Monastery



6.- Relics Room

The collection of relics that the Abbey has accumulated since its foundation, and over the centuries, is displayed within the dignified sobriety characteristic of Cistercian Art, remaining free from the wealth that these relics were typically surrounded with.

The grandeur of the relics is expressed here without the need for elaborate display cases, which, though interesting and artistically valuable, are not used. The highlight is the reliquary cabinet commissioned by Abbess Leonor de Osorio in the 16th century.

Relics room

LOCATION

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